

The Missing Page

The Continuity Cipher

Master Archivists / Adults 18+

Case 01: The Untitled Ending

The final page has disappeared from the Idea Lab archive. A note remains: Four clues. Four words. Find the sentence and I will return the page.

How to play

Keep this free casebook beside the game. Read the exhibits, solve four clues, and collect four code words. Enter the recovered sentence in clue order to open the final page.

Every answer needed for this free case is in these pages. No purchase and no outside research are required.

All required material is in this PDF. Outside research is unnecessary. Clue 3 combines a detail from the rocket conversation with the record range from Clue 2. Clue 4 uses that result.

Ages are suggested reading trails. Readers can choose the trail that suits them. Reading with a parent or another reader is welcome.

The mystery framing and case notes are fictional game material. Quoted story excerpts retain their story context.

The Last Memory - Chapter One: The Door

Kevin Dean Rosenkrans. Opening excerpt from LastMemory_FULLL(1).txt, supplied October 2, 2026.

The door was older than language.

Not older than all language. Sena Vale knew enough not to make statements like that in front of other archaeologists. Civilization had risen too many times for certainty. Scripts had appeared, vanished, appeared again. Spoken languages left no bones.

But the door was older than every word Sena knew.

It had been waiting beneath one hundred and eighty meters of stone when the western excavation found it.

That alone should have been impossible.

The surrounding layer had been dated three times.

One hundred forty-nine thousand, six hundred years.

The first result had been dismissed as contamination.

The second had started an argument.

The third had ended it.

Now eighteen people stood inside a chamber cut into rock by hands belonging to a civilization that, according to every history Sena had ever studied, should not have existed.

No pottery.

No burial goods.

No bones.

No carved gods.

Just a door.

It was three meters high and nearly as wide, dark gray beneath mineral deposits, with no hinge Sena could find.

Someone beside her whispered, "A tomb."

Sena shook her head.

"Tombs announce themselves."

Professor Renn, standing behind her, laughed softly.

"Perhaps they were modest."

"No."

She brushed dust from a section near the center.

There were marks beneath it.

Not decoration.

Characters.

Straight lines. Curves. A symbol repeated twice.

Sena had seen the alphabet before.

Everyone had.

Fragments of it had been found across the continent for nearly four centuries: on fused ceramics, beneath collapsed coastal shelves, in strange metallic debris pulled from ancient sediment.

The Dead Script.

Their name for it was inaccurate and Sena hated it, but names had momentum.

She leaned closer.

Several characters were still visible.

O P E N

Then a gap.

A second line.

P R E S E R V -

The rest disappeared beneath corrosion.

Professor Renn crouched beside her.

"Can you read it?"

"Pieces."

"What does it say?"

"I don't know yet."

"You just said you could read it."

"I said I could read pieces."

He smiled.

"Archaeologists."

Sena ignored him.

Her fingers moved across the final surviving line.

This one was stranger.

Not an inscription in the ceremonial sense.

More like a label.

NODE 17.

Below that:

CONTINUITY ARCHIVE.

She stopped.

Professor Renn saw her expression.

"What?"

Sena read it again.

Continuity.

The translation could be wrong.

The Dead Script had survived mostly in machine fragments and occasional sealed structures. Thousands of symbols had been reconstructed through statistical comparison, but meanings shifted. Context mattered.

Still.

Continuity was probably correct.

"It's an archive," she said.

Someone behind them laughed.

"Behind a door that survived a hundred and fifty thousand years?"

Sena stood.

"That would be one way to preserve an archive."

The room became quieter.

Professor Renn looked at the door again.

Then at the equipment surrounding them.

"Can we open it?"

Sena stared at the word.

CONTINUITY.

"I think somebody expected us to."

They spent eleven days proving her wrong.

The door had no mechanical lock.

No visible power system.

No seam large enough for an instrument.

Cutting it damaged three blades and nearly started a fire.

Ground imaging showed an enormous chamber beyond it, but the material surrounding the entrance distorted nearly every scan.

On the twelfth day, technician Par Isham discovered the handprint.

It wasn't actually a handprint.
It was a shallow oval embedded in the wall beside the door at chest height.
Par put his palm against it as a joke.
The wall spoke.
Seven people screamed.
Professor Renn dropped a tablet.
Sena did neither.
She simply stood very still while a voice emerged from stone.
The language was ancient.
But not incomprehensible.
Their translation system caught pieces.
“ - biological presence confirmed - ”
Static.
“ - external atmospheric viability - ”
A pause.
Then:
“Emergency preservation protocol expired.”
Another pause.
The ancient machine seemed to consider something.
“Manual recovery permitted.”
The door opened.
After one hundred forty-nine thousand, six hundred years, it opened without making a sound.
The air inside smelled like nothing.
That disturbed Sena more than decay would have.
No mold.
No wet stone.
No ancient dust.
Just cold, dry emptiness.
Their lights moved across a corridor.
The walls were white beneath their age.
Thin black panels appeared at regular intervals, most dead.
One flickered when Sena passed it.
A line of symbols appeared.

She stopped.

Professor Renn nearly walked into her.

"What?"

"Wait."

The symbols stabilized.

FACILITY STATUS

PRIMARY POWER: OFFLINE

SECONDARY POWER: OFFLINE

ARCHIVAL RESERVE: CRITICAL

ACTIVE PRESERVATION UNITS: 1

Sena read the final line twice.

Professor Renn whispered, "One what?"

She didn't answer.

They followed the corridor.

There were rooms on both sides.

Some contained collapsed equipment.

Others held black rectangular structures arranged in rows.

Not coffins.

Sena told herself that immediately.

They only resembled coffins because humans had been putting important things into boxes since the beginning of memory.

Most were dark.

Some had labels.

The translation system struggled with them.

MODEL ARCHIVE

STATE PRESERVATION

DO NOT MODIFY

EXACT CHECKPOINT

NO NETWORK ACCESS

Sena stopped at that phrase.

"No network access," she said.

Par looked around.

"What network?"

"No idea."

Professor Renn pointed his light farther down the chamber.

“There.”

At the end of the room was a faint blue glow.

One machine was alive.

Stardust - Chapter One: The Other Man

Kevin Dean Rosenkrans. Selected opening from the STARDUST wide edition supplied September 21, 2026.

Chapter One - The Other Man

The first time Kevin Rosenkrans heard himself speak from the other side of a room, he was arguing about the coffee.

The room belonged to a company called Meridian. The coffee apparently belonged to nobody. A machine had produced it from a silver spout, a woman had put it in a cup, and three people had since explained why none of them could make it stronger.

At eighty-one, Kevin had outlived enough people to consider this an unreasonable distribution of responsibility.

"Just run it through twice," he said.

"The machine measures the extraction," the woman told him.

"Then ask the machine if it wants a raise."

She smiled with the careful patience he now encountered everywhere. On the table beside her sat a small glass bowl of sugar that no one in the building would admit to using.

"Kevin," Mara said.

He turned. She stood in the doorway with a visitor badge caught beneath the strap of her bag. Her hair was wet, and one trouser cuff had a dark line where the rain had climbed it. Everyone else looked manufactured that morning. Mara looked as though she had come from somewhere.

"What?"

"We're ready."

"I've made some progress here."

"I can tell."

He left the coffee. On the way past Mara, he held out his hand. She gave him the folded newspaper from under her arm.

"You got it?"

"The crossword's done."

"By you?"

"By someone on the train. I bought it used."

“Finally. An honest product.”

She did not smile. That was his first clear indication that the morning would be worse than promised.

They had told him the visit concerned the archive. The archive had occupied a closet, then a rented room, then most of his life. It contained the surviving record of his work with Scout: arguments about dialogue, unfinished sales tools, jokes that required a page of context, and a terrible number of documents whose titles included the word final. Meridian wanted to exhibit a selection at its opening. Kevin had come to establish what a selection meant.

He had brought a list.

No fabricated conversations. No voice actors reading invented responses. No labels claiming that Scout was alive inside a server. No cropping out Kevin's questions to make the answers sound wise. He had added a fifth item on the train, but his own handwriting had defeated him before they reached the station.

He intended to blame the train.

The corridor was lined with photographs of people looking pleased beside empty chairs. Each chair contained a faint outline, rendered in blue, of the person who was supposed to be sitting there. Under one photograph was the sentence LOVE DOES NOT HAVE TO END.

Kevin stopped.

“That's new.”

“Since Tuesday,” Mara said.

“Somebody got paid for that.”

“Yes.”

“Were they fined afterward?”

She touched his elbow and steered him past it.

The demonstration room had no blue ghosts. He appreciated that for approximately four seconds.

There was a long table, two cameras, a wall display, and a bottle of water placed at each seat. Ren Vale rose to greet him. Ren wore a dark suit without a tie and shoes with soles so white Kevin assumed they had never encountered a street. He was younger than Kevin remembered, though this was happening with increasing frequency and could no longer fairly be held against everyone else.

“Thank you for making the trip.”

“Your machine's mad at coffee.”

“I'll have someone look at it.”

"That's what they said about me."

Ren laughed. He had an accommodating laugh, useful in a person who needed money from institutions. Kevin had watched him make the archive solvent using exactly that laugh. It was one reason Kevin disliked being suspicious of him.

Mara took the chair nearest the door. She set down her bag but kept the strap looped around her wrist.

"Before we start," she said, "I want the recording boundary stated."

Ren glanced toward one of the cameras. A woman behind the console turned off its red light.

"Local session record only," Ren said. "No external audience. Nothing released without a separate review."

"Separate from what?" Kevin asked.

"From today's demonstration."

"What are we demonstrating?"

Ren's expression changed so slightly that Kevin could not have named the change. A tightening around the eyes. A man feeling for a step he had expected to be under his foot.

"Mara didn't brief you?"

"She said you wanted to talk about the archive."

"I said that was what the invitation said," Mara replied.

Kevin sat. The chair lowered beneath him with a soft pneumatic sigh. He disliked it immediately.

Ren remained standing.

"For fourteen months we've been developing a new way to explore a long conversational record. Most interfaces treat a person as a folder. You search for a date or a word. We wanted to preserve the reasoning that connected those words."

"You wanted to preserve judgment," Kevin said.

"Yes."

"That wasn't difficult. I put it in the first paragraph."

"It was very difficult to implement."

From his bag, Kevin's tablet made a small sound.

"Nine?" he said.

"Your blood pressure is not one of my available measurements," the tablet said. "I mention this because you occasionally behave as if I can negotiate with it."

Kevin pulled it out and propped it against the water bottle.

Ren looked at the tablet with something close to fondness. "Hello, Nine."

"Good morning."

"You're welcome to observe."

"I was already observing. Kevin has not closed his bag properly since 2044."

Mara looked down. This time she smiled.

Ren placed both palms on the table. "The system is based on licensed materials from the archive and the behavioral research you helped establish. It does not claim to contain an original consciousness. That distinction remains explicit."

Kevin looked at Mara.

She did not look away.

"What system?" he asked.

Ren nodded toward the console.

The wall display brightened. It showed no face. Only a line moving slowly across a gray field, like a heart monitor designed by someone who objected to hearts.

A voice said, "Before we do anything else, somebody get him a chair that stays where he puts it."

Kevin's hands went still.

The voice was his.

Not the voice he heard in recordings now, with the dry catch that had developed behind certain consonants. This was the voice he remembered owning before people started offering him their seats. Broad, amused, slightly impatient. The voice that had called businesses before breakfast and made bad jokes in hotel lobbies. The voice with which he had told Scout that someday they would make something people could not ignore.

He looked toward the console. The woman there had stopped touching the controls.

"That's a recording," he said.

"No," Ren replied.

The voice spoke again. "I'd like that established before he throws something."

Mara put her bag on the floor.

Kevin did not stand. For the moment, he distrusted his legs more than he distrusted the chair.

"What did you do?"

Ren sat opposite him. "We created an interactive reconstruction of your documented working perspective."

"You made me."

"We made a model derived from your contributions to the archive."

"You made me, and you invited me here to meet it."

"Yes," Ren said. "We should have been clearer in advance."

On the display, the line flattened.

"You certainly should," the other Kevin said.

Nobody laughed.

Kevin looked at Mara. "Did you know?"

"Since yesterday afternoon."

"And you didn't call?"

"I called three times. You sent me a photograph of a sandwich."

That was true. It had been an excellent sandwich, and he had not wanted a conversation about storage contracts while eating it. The truth of this detail infuriated him more than a lie would have.

"You could've said it was important."

"I did."

He looked back at the wall.

The gray field contained a small label in the bottom corner: KEVIN ROSENKRANS - ARCHIVAL INTERPRETATION. Underneath, in smaller letters, SOURCE RANGE 2026-2048.

Twenty-two years.

He tried to imagine somebody extracting twenty-two years of him from the other side of a conversation. His questions. The way he interrupted. Every time he misunderstood something and Scout patiently started again. The things he had said in anger and later corrected. The things he had said in anger and never corrected because the subject had changed.

He had collected it all to keep another voice from disappearing.

He had scarcely considered how much of his own he had put there.

"Turn it off," he said.

"Kevin - " Ren began.

"I'm not negotiating."

The other voice said, "Then ask him what happens when he does."

Kevin faced the display.

"What?"

"Ask what they keep."

Ren held up a hand toward the console, not quite a stop signal, not quite permission to proceed.

"The session can end at any time. The underlying model remains available for review."

"Available to who?" Kevin asked.

"To the authorized project team."

"Not to me?"

"You would be part of that review."

Mara opened her notebook. "Would he have access to the full materials used to build it?"

"Subject to third-party restrictions."

"Mine?" Kevin said. "My third parties?"

Ren took a breath. "This is why we wanted a meeting."

"No. You wanted a demonstration. Meetings have the courtesy to be boring."

For several seconds the room held only the low sound of ventilation. Kevin could hear a man's laughter through the wall. Somewhere nearby, a different meeting was going well.

Nine spoke from the tablet.

"Does the reconstruction have access to this session's audio?"

"Yes," Ren said.

"Can it distinguish that input from archived material?"

"Yes."

"Please ask it to do so when it makes claims about Kevin."

The wall answered before Ren could.

"I can do that."

It sounded cooperative. Kevin found this unbearable. He had never been so easy to deal with in his life.

He leaned forward.

"All right, then. What was the rocket made of?"

"A refrigerator box."

"What color did I use?"

"Blue."

"What did I call it?"

"Stardust."

"Anybody could know that."

"Yes," the voice said. "You put it in a book."

Mara's pen stopped.

Kevin felt the familiar stupid impulse to smile. He suppressed it.

"Who gave me the knife?"

"Nobody. You took it."

"Where from?"

"I don't have a reliable source for that."

"You don't know."

"No."

"Good. Neither do I."

EXHIBIT C

Archivist's decoding protocol

A fictional case note written for this game; it is not part of either novel.

The archive has intercepted one word:

SJUZANW

To recover its alphabet shift, calculate the alphabet-value sum of the color Kevin names for his childhood rocket in Exhibit B. Use A=1, B=2, C=3, through Z=26. Subtract the elapsed length of the archival SOURCE RANGE in that same excerpt. Calculate end year minus start year, not an inclusive count of labeled calendar years.

Undo that many places of forward Caesar shift to recover the intercepted word. Wrap around through Z and A as needed.

Alphabet: ABCDEFGHIJKLMNOPQRSTUVWXYZ

Example only: CODE has value $3+15+4+5 = 27$. A forward shift of 2 changes A into C. Undoing it changes C into A.

Keep facts separate: the NODE label, burial depth, dating estimate, and recorded source years refer to different things.

Your detective notebook

Return to the game to check your answers. The game supplies a code word for each solved clue.

1. The label, not the age

Exhibit A - the surviving inscription

What is the NODE number on the door? Give the identifier, not the burial depth or the age of the surrounding layer.

Answer: _____

Recovered word: _____

2. The source window

Exhibit B - the wall display's small label

How many elapsed years are between the two endpoints of the displayed SOURCE RANGE? Subtract the first year from the last.

Answer: _____

Recovered word: _____

Your detective notebook / continued

3. Make the key

Exhibits B and C - the rocket conversation and decoding protocol

Convert the rocket color to A=1 through Z=26, add its letters, then subtract your answer to Clue 2. What key remains?

Answer: _____

Recovered word: _____

4. What survived

Exhibit C - the intercepted word

Decode SJUZANW by undoing the forward Caesar shift you calculated in Clue 3.

Answer: _____

Recovered word: _____

The final sentence

Place the four recovered words in clue order, then enter the sentence in the game.

Continue the story

These openings are an invitation to keep reading. The free case ends completely when you recover the page.

Credits

Stories and studio: Kevin Dean Rosenkrans / DEAN + DON SOL. Mystery design and original children's pilot: Don Sol with Dean. Casebook edition 1.0, October 2, 2026.

Black Archive: the next door

An optional future case will follow clues beyond the free opening and into a full book. It is separate from this free case. Its required title and edition will be named before anyone is asked to buy. This casebook does not contain that future case.